

SEPTIC SYSTEM MAINTENANCE SCHEDULE

A one-page reference to keep your system healthy, avoid a five-figure drain-field failure, and prove a maintenance history when you sell.

HOW OFTEN TO PUMP YOUR TANK

Estimated **years between pump-outs**, by tank size and household size. These are planning estimates — pump sooner if solids reach about one-third of the tank, or if an inspection says so.

TANK SIZE	1 PERSON	2 PEOPLE	3 PEOPLE	4 PEOPLE	5 PEOPLE	6 PEOPLE
750 gallon	9	4	3	2	1.5	1
1,000 gallon	12	6	4	3	2	2
1,250 gallon	16	8	5	3.5	3	2.5
1,500 gallon	19	9	6	4	3.5	3

Rule of thumb: The EPA recommends most household septic systems be inspected roughly every 3 years and pumped every 3–5 years. A garbage disposal, a home office, or frequent guests shorten these intervals. When in doubt, measure the sludge layer instead of guessing.

ROUTINE CARE CHECKLIST

EVERY DAY • Spread out laundry loads across the week • Fix running toilets and dripping taps quickly • Only flush the "3 P's": pee, poop, paper • Use water-efficient fixtures where you can	EVERY 1–3 YEARS • Clean the effluent filter (or at each pump-out) • Have the tank inspected by a pro • Measure sludge & scum layers • Check baffles, lids, and risers for damage	SEASONAL & ONGOING • Protect the drain field: no driving, parking, or building over it; divert roof and surface water away from it. • Landscape smart: grass over the field is ideal; keep trees and deep roots well clear. • Skip the additives: a healthy tank grows the bacteria it needs — save your money.
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NEVER PUT THESE DOWN THE DRAIN

• Wipes, paper towels, "flushable" wipes • Cooking grease, fats, and oils • Coffee grounds and food scraps • Cat litter, diapers, cigarette butts	• Paints, solvents, and harsh chemicals • Medications and antibacterial cleaners in bulk • Dental floss and hygiene products • Large volumes of bleach at once
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WARNING SIGNS — CALL A PROFESSIONAL

Slow drains & gurgling	Multiple slow fixtures or gurgling toilets point to a full tank or a blockage.
Sewage odors	Smells indoors or over the tank/field mean gases are escaping — act promptly.
Wet or lush spots	Soggy ground or unusually green grass over the drain field can signal a failing field.
Backups	Sewage backing into the lowest drains is an emergency — stop water use and call a pro.

YOUR SERVICE LOG

Keep this filled in. A documented maintenance history reassures buyers and inspectors — and helps you spot a system that's trending toward trouble.

DATE	SERVICE PERFORMED	PROVIDER	COST	NEXT DUE

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A note from SepticSteward. This schedule is general guidance, not a substitute for a licensed inspection or your local health-department rules, which always take precedence. Save it, print it, and tape it inside a cabinet near your records. More free guides at [SepticSteward.com/guides](https://septicsteward.com/guides).